

com's role is limited to issuing technical feasibility approval, installing the net meter, and inspecting the system," Singh said in Parliament. Once the system is installed and inspected, the subsidy is deposited directly into the bank account of the consumer.

There are, however, a few things that one needs to keep in mind when applying for a subsidy. First, the solar panels should be manufactured in the country, as subsidies are not available for panels not assembled in India. Second, the electricity connection should be in your name and one cannot apply for more than 85% of the existing sanctioned load. Moreover, there should be consistency in your name in all the documents.

"It is very important to ensure that there is consistency in your name across your bank account, electricity bill, and Aadhaar card. The subsidy may not be transferred if there is a mismatch. Additionally, the connection should be in your name and not your forefathers'," explains Sahoo of Prakruti. Moreover, one always needs to ensure that a vendor is registered with MNRE to get subsidy benefits.

NET METERING

This net metering initiative enables you to lower your electricity bills during sunnier days and even sell surplus energy back to the grid, offering an opportunity to have an additional income. It helps in feeding the excess units back into the grid when more energy is produced than consumed.

The energy meter essentially 'nets' out the power that was consumed and the power that was generated. In practical terms, a homeowner might use a certain amount of electricity during peak sun hours and then feed the same or a greater amount of solar-generated electricity back into the grid.

Hence, one primary advantage of net metering

is that it provides financial credits to solar energy users.

"The excess units generated in a month get adjusted in the next bill. Then at the end of the financial year, the discom pays you for surplus units generated in the last 12 months at 75% of the existing rates," says Agarwal.

However, it is important to note that grid-connected solar systems cannot supply power during outages unless equipped with a separate battery for operation.

"In regions experiencing prolonged power cuts, grid-connected systems become ineffective due to the absence of power backup. Incorporating a battery into the grid-connected system could potentially resolve this issue. However, the government subsidy does not cover the installation of such hybrid systems," says Sahoo.

Regular cleaning of panels is another point to keep in mind. "I need to clean solar panels every 15-20 days as dust gets accumulated. It does not take much time but I need to do it regularly," says Ray.

Last but not least, installing the system and getting the subsidy can be a time-consuming process at times. "Though MNRE is pushing very hard, at times discoms do not provide technical feasibility reports on time, which delays the whole process. Similarly, net metering takes time," says Agarwal.

The storage capacity of discoms is another issue that needs to be resolved before the government plans to expand the RTS footprint in the country. "Discoms do not have enough infrastructure capacity currently. For 40 GW, we need to come up with more infrastructure and storage facilities for discoms,"

says Agarwal.

As India marches on to reach the full potential of harnessing solar energy, a few bottlenecks need to be fixed before RTS can bring a ray of hope to more people's lives—just like it has to Amit Ray. **BT**

@teena_kaushal

SUBSIDY RATE

For residential households

1 kW: SUBSIDY

RATE (₹) 30,000

2 kW: SUBSIDY

RATE (₹) 60,000

3 kW*: SUBSIDY

RATE (₹) 78,000

*₹18,000 PER KW FOR ADDITIONAL CAPACITY OVER 3 KW

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